Interview Question Outline

Luxury Resort Traveler Depth Interviews · 30 min · Semi-structured

Interviewer: _____ **Participant (first name):** _____

Date: _____ **Format:** ☐ Zoom ☐ In person **Party:** ☐ Couple ☐ Family ☐ Multigenerational **Status:** ☐ Non-guest ☐ Past guest

Blind design: never name the sponsoring resort or its competitor. All stimuli are labeled Resort A / Resort B. Concept card order this interview: ☐ A first ☐ B first

Materials Checklist

- ☐ Concept A and Concept B message cards
- ☐ Unbranded Instagram-style image sets (Resort A, Resort B)
- ☐ 3–4 anonymized review excerpts per resort
- ☐ Six attribute cards for the ranking exercise
- ☐ Recording set up; consent statement ready

Part 1 · Beginning (6 min)

Opening checklist (3.5 min)

1. Introduce yourself (USC Annenberg graduate student) and the topic: how travelers choose and experience luxury resort vacations; ~30 min; images and messages to react to later.
2. Consent: recording heard only by the 5-person team and instructor; class project only; anonymous quotes; recording deleted by end of fall semester; can skip or stop anytime. Ask: "Do I have your consent to participate and to record?"
3. Record verbal consent on tape. Collect first name only. Confirm gift card incentive and timing.
4. Ground rules: no right or wrong answers; I didn't design anything, so be fully honest; silence phone; ask if anything is unclear.

Participant introduction (1 min)

I1 Tell me a little about yourself and who you usually travel with. If your ideal vacation were a movie, what would its title be, and who would be in the cast?

Silently confirm screener data (travel party, guest/non-guest). Do not read it aloud.

Warm-up (2.5 min)

W1 Take me back to the most memorable luxury trip you've taken in the last few years. Walk me through the moment you knew it was special.

- *Probe:* What exactly happened? Who were you with?
- *Probe:* How much of that came from the place, the people, or something the staff did?

W2 Finish this sentence: "A resort that costs $2,000 a night should always…" Now tell me what separates that resort from a $600-a-night one.

- *Probe:* Where does that expectation come from?

Part 2 · Key Questions (~18 min)

Flow: how people decide → what matters → travel party needs → reactions to stimuli. Follow the participant's energy, but cover all four topics.

Topic A · The Decision Journey (RQ1) · 4 min

K1 Walk me through how you chose the last luxury resort you booked, from the first spark of inspiration to the moment you paid.

- *Probe:* Where did the idea first come from? Which sources did you lean on most (advisor, social media, review sites, the resort's own website)? Why those?
- *Probe:* How did you narrow it down to your final two or three? What knocked the others out?

K2 Tell me about a moment in that process when you almost didn't book. What made you hesitate, and what got you past it?

K3 When you scroll through guest reviews or other travelers' posts, what are you hunting for? Describe a review that made you trust a place, and one that made you scroll right past it.

Topic B · What Really Matters (RQ1) · 5 min

K4 *[Imagined scenario]* **Imagine it's day three at your dream resort, and you text a friend, "This place is worth every dollar." What just happened that made you send that?**

- *Probe:* Why that moment? What would have made it fall flat?

K5 Describe the best meal you've had at a resort. What made it more than just good food?

- *Probe:* How did the setting, the staff, or the ingredients play into it?
- *Probe:* How much does a resort's dining shape whether you book it in the first place?

K6 Tell me about a time resort staff made you feel genuinely taken care of. What did they do differently?

- *Probe:* How would you describe the difference between service that feels personal and service that feels scripted?

K7 Many Hawai'i resorts talk about their architecture, natural setting, and cultural heritage. How do those things weigh in your decision, compared with what we just discussed?

- *Probe:* When you compare Hawai'i resorts online, how do they start to blend together? What, if anything, makes one stand out?

Topic C · Travel Party Needs & Concerns (RQ2) · 4 min

Ask everyone the same questions; use probes to draw out details specific to their party (family, multigenerational, couple).

K8 Think about the people you usually travel with. What has to be true about a resort before it makes your shortlist?

- *Probe:* What does each person in your group need to feel the trip was worth it?
- *Probe:* How do you balance private space with time together?

K9 *[Projective]* **Imagine the last night of your next luxury trip. Describe the moment that tells you that you chose the right place.**

- *Probe:* Who's there, and what's happening? What would make that moment fall flat?

K10 **How do the sources you rely on, such as social media, reviews, or a travel advisor, shape what you expect from a resort before you arrive?**

- *Probe:* Tell me about a time a place didn't live up to what you saw or heard, or exceeded it.
- *Probe:* When a resort's marketing seems aimed at a different kind of traveler than you, how does that affect your interest?

K11 **What would make you worry you're paying a premium for something that won't deliver? How do you reassure yourself before booking?**

Topic D · Perceptions & Messaging (RQ2) · 5 min

K12 *[Unaided recall — before any stimulus]* **If a friend asked you to recommend a luxury resort on Hawai'i Island, which ones would you mention, and how would you describe each one?**

- *Probe:* Where did you hear about these resorts? What do you remember most clearly about each one?

K13 *[Visual stimulus]* **[Show Resort A and Resort B image sets] If you had to book one of these for your next trip right now, which would you choose?**

- *Probe:* Which photo made you decide? What do you think you'd spend most of your time doing there?
- *Probe:* In what ways do the two look similar?

Stimulus for K13–K14 · Resort A image set

[Stimulus image omitted from the public version]

Stimulus for K13–K14 · Resort B image set

[Stimulus image omitted from the public version]

K14 **Looking at these photos, what can't you tell about each resort that you'd want to know before booking?**

- *Probe:* For example, what the food is like, how staff treat guests, or what there is to do. Which of these matters most to you?

K15 *[Review stimulus]* **[Show review excerpts] Which review makes you most want to stay at that resort? Which line in it won you over?**

- *Probe:* After reading the reviews, how has your choice of resort changed? What made you change your mind, or stick with your original choice?

Stimulus for K15 · Resort A review excerpts

[Stimulus image omitted from the public version]

Stimulus for K15 · Resort B review excerpts

[Stimulus image omitted from the public version]

K16 *[Concept test]* **[Show Concept A and B cards — rotate order] If you came across these two as Instagram ads, which one would make you stop scrolling, and why?**

Stimulus for K16 · Concept A and Concept B Instagram ads (print separately and rotate order)

[Stimulus image omitted from the public version]

- *Probe:* In each ad, which words stand out to you, good or bad?
- *Probe:* In the ad you prefer, what could be added that would make you click "book" right away?

Part 3 · Winding Down (6 min)

E1 *[Ranking exercise]* **[Lay out the six attribute cards] Based on everything we've talked about, please put these in order from most to least important when you choose a resort like this. Talk me through your thinking as you go.**

Rank ___ Culinary excellence and fine dining
Rank ___ Personalized, intuitive service
Rank ___ Room space, layout and privacy
Rank ___ Photogenic aesthetics and atmosphere
Rank ___ Standalone accommodations and natural setting
Rank ___ On-property activities and cultural programming

- *Probe:* What made your top choice beat number two?
- *Probe:* What would have to change for the bottom card to move up?

Stimulus for E1 · Six attribute cards (print, cut apart, and shuffle before each interview)

Attribute cards (E1) · cut along the dashed lines



E2 **Picture two resorts at exactly the same price. What would tip you toward one? And what, if anything, would make you willing to pay more for one?**

E3 **If you could give a luxury Hawai‘i resort’s marketing team one piece of advice for reaching someone like you, what would it be?**

E4 **What else about choosing a resort like this matters to you that we haven’t talked about?**

E5 **Close: thank the participant. “What questions do you have for me before we wrap up?”**

Remind them: responses stay anonymous; incentive arrives within 5 days.

Appendix · Image Stimulus Sheets (K13–K14)

The next two pages are shown to participants. They carry only the labels Resort A and Resort B.

- Use the same six shot types in the same positions for both resorts, so the comparison is about the resort and not about which set has nicer photos.
- Match photo quality: similar time of day, lighting, crop, and filters.
- Remove anything that identifies the resort: logos, signage, watermarks, branded towels or menus, and recognizable landmark names.
- Delete the grey label text under each photo once the image is in, or keep it short and neutral.
- Record where each photo came from (e.g., the resort's press/media kit) in the team's internal notes, not on these pages.

Resort A

[Insert photo A1]
1 · Setting / aerial view

[Insert photo A2]
2 · Accommodation exterior

[Insert photo A3]
3 · Room interior

[Insert photo A4]
4 · Pool or beach

[Insert photo A5]
5 · Dining

[Insert photo A6]
6 · Activity / culture

Resort B

[Insert photo B1]
1 · Setting / aerial view

[Insert photo B2]
2 · Accommodation exterior

[Insert photo B3]
3 · Room interior

[Insert photo B4]
4 · Pool or beach

[Insert photo B5]
5 · Dining

[Insert photo B6]
6 · Activity / culture